Understanding the Christian Gospel

and How It Works

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Preface

The following explanation of the gospel is my understanding of the plain teaching of the bible. I am committed to what is called the *Perspicuity*[1] *of Scripture*, i.e., although the bible is not clear on everything it says (it was addressed to another age and another culture) it is clear on the gospel, ie., the information we need in order to be saved. So a person of average intelligence can, through a diligent reading of the bible, understand the gospel sufficiently to benefit from its saving power. This doesn't mean that every reader will benefit from the gospel; understanding it, although a necessary condition for salvation, is not a sufficient condition by itself and we will see why as we continue through this book.

I am committed to the doctrine of verbal inspiration, ie., that the whole bible is supernaturally inspired[2] by God and is therefore verbally inerrant in the original languages. For a more comprehensive explanation of my position on this the reader is urged to read the Westminster Confession of Faith, chapter 1 "Of the Holy Scripture".

The following discussion on the gospel is from a Reformed[3] perspective, ie., it is not theologically neutral, which, in my opinion, is philosophically and psychologically impossible anyway. The Reformed perspective is particularistic[4] and in harmony with the Westminster Confession of Faith, the Belgic

1 See-through-able-ness; transparency.
2 Greek: θεόπνευστος - *theopneustos*: God breathed out.
3 Reformed - Theology of the Reformation; especially Calvinism.

Confession, The Canons of Dort, The Baptist Confession of 1689, the Savoy Declaration and the 39 Articles of the Anglican Church. I have not tried to defend that position exegetically as that is not the purpose of this book. I have, however, included a list of competent authors and their publications which, if consulted, will go a long way to convincing the open minded reader of the correctness of the Reformed perspective. Having said that, I do believe that in most, if not all, of the discussions I have had with semi-Pelagians[5] over the years in regard to the divine initiative, they all seem to gravitate to the one burning question: what about man's free will? In response to this I have pretty much devoted the first chapter to an explanation of how the "free will" of fallen man can and does interoperate with the sovereign work of God in salvation. It is my hope that this will clear the way for the rest of the book to make some sense to the semi-Pelagian reader.

I am not politically correct and don't even pretend to be. So if you are expecting "they" and "them" instead of "he" and "him" or "she" and "her" you will not find them in this book. Most of my references to "man" and "men" include women as they do in the original languages of the bible. To summarise my position on the sexes, let me quote from Galatians 3:28,

> There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither bond nor free, there is neither male nor female: for ye are all one in Christ Jesus.

4 Particularistic: the view that God saves particular persons and not people in general.

5 Semi-Pelagianism: The view that man can be saved partly by his own effort and partly by God's.

> 29 And if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring, heirs according to promise.

The aim of this book is to equip Christians to share the gospel with their unsaved friends and relatives. I have found over the many years of ministry that probably the greatest impediment Christians have to sharing the gospel is a feeling of inadequacy. It is my conviction that a thorough understanding of the gospel and how it works will do much to remove that impediment and create a new confidence in communicating the plain and simple facts of the gospel to the unsaved.

All scripture quotes in this book are from the King James Version of the bible.

1. The Problem

So why do we need the gospel? First, the Greek word for gospel, *euangelion,* literally means “good message” implying that it has the potential to do the hearer “good”. To understand just how good, we need to know something about the unbeliever.

There are a number of passages in the bible that paint a very sobering description of the natural man, i.e., man as he comes

from the womb without any spiritual modifications. Ephesians 2:1-3 takes us to the heart of the matter:

> And you hath he quickened, who were dead in trespasses and sins;
>
> 2 Wherein in time past ye walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, the spirit that now worketh in the children of disobedience:
>
> 3 Among whom also we all had our conversation in times past in the lusts of our flesh, fulfilling the desires of the flesh and of the mind; and were by nature the children of wrath, even as others.

Here Paul tells the Ephesians that prior to conversion they were “dead” in sin. So what does this mean? Obviously this death is not biological, and if we turn to Luke 9:60 we see Jesus using this same word to describe the unconverted of his day.

> 60 Jesus said unto him, Let the dead bury their dead: but go thou and preach the kingdom of God.

To be “dead” in this context means to be totally unaffected by and unresponsive to the things of God just as biological death is to be totally unaffected by and unresponsive to the things of the natural world. The Ephesians followed the "prince of the power of the air, the spirit that is now at work in the sons of disobedience" (See also John 8:42-47). This describes a

dynamic that makes the unbeliever wholly opposed to anything that pleases God.

Another passage of similar meaning is John 3:19-20.

> 19 And this is the condemnation, that light is come into the world, and men loved darkness rather than light, because their deeds were evil.
>
> 20 For every one that doeth evil hateth the light, neither cometh to the light, lest his deeds should be reproved.

Although the word “dead” is not used here we see that “men”, ie, all people, in their natural state cannot respond to Christ and his teaching and prefer to remain in darkness. Jesus is describing mankind in their natural unconverted state and while they may be alive to the things of the world they are dead to the things of God.

Finally, in building a case for grace[6], Paul, in Romans 3:10-18, gives us a particularly hard hitting list of vices that leave fallen man without a spiritual leg to stand on.

> 10 As it is written, There is none righteous, no, not one: 11 There is none that understandeth, there is none that seeketh after God. 12 They are all gone out of the way, they are together become unprofitable; there is none that doeth good, no, not one. 13 Their throat is an open sepulchre; with their

6 Greek: χάρις - *grace;* unmerited favour of God.

> tongues they have used deceit; the poison of asps is
> under their lips: 14 Whose mouth is full of cursing
> and bitterness: 15 Their feet are swift to shed
> blood: 16 Destruction and misery are in their ways:
> 17 And the way of peace have they not known:
> 18 There is no fear of God before their eyes.

So how do we reconcile this view with the scores of unbelievers we know as fair, kind and friendly people? To answer this question we must understand that to be righteous in the sight of God we must love God and seek to please him. In other words the bible has a God-centred perspective of the good and the bad. It's not just what we do that defines a good work or an evil work but also *why* we do it. Unless the very best things we do are motivated from a heart of love for God and a desire to please him, they are not "good" in the sight of God, no matter how good they may appear to us.

To illustrate this: when I was a child I can remember my father asking me a week before Christmas whether I had bought my mother a Christmas present. I would invariably answer "Not yet". In fact I hadn't even thought about it up until then. I knew that if there was no Christmas present for Mum under the tree from me on Christmas day I would not be popular with my father. So, was the present a sign of my love for Mum or a sign of my desire to get my father off my back?

The bottom line here is that if there is no love for God in the human heart then it doesn't matter how "good" the act is in terms of its effect on others, it can never be acceptable to God. If my mother found out the circumstances under which I gave

her the present she would have been quite disappointed, not because of any deficiency in the present itself but in its significance as a sign of my love.

From the biblical descriptions given above it is pretty plain that the natural man has no love for God in his heart whatsoever. There can be no compromise here, and unless we have a God-centred understanding of the good and the bad we will never accept what is essentially a non-intuitive but absolutely biblical ethic. It is a natural consequence of what the apostle Paul says in Romans 11:36

> For of him, and through him, and to him, are all things: to whom be glory for ever. Amen.

So for the natural man a love for God can never be the motivation for doing anything. Conversely, it means that everything he does is evil continuously. Again, let me reiterate that this has nothing to do with any intrinsic good or bad in the act itself but everything to do with the toxic relationship the natural man has with God.

We are now in a position to see that the natural man can never initiate reconciliation with God. The very best we can expect from him is a total disinterest in God. That’s not to say that he has no propensity to worship a god of his own imagination. Because man is religious by nature he is prone to invent his own god and to worship that god, but it will never be the god of the bible. That much we can be sure of. This is made plain by the apostle Paul in Romans 1:18-32.

Probably the best way to describe the natural man's relationship with God is that of *enmity*. The natural man "hates" God, not in the sense that he is walking around shaking his fist at the heavens, but because he has, at best, nothing but a cold indifference toward his creator. And it would be a mistake to think that God somehow remains neutral in the midst of all that enmity, for the bible frequently refers to the "wrath" of God under which the natural man labours, being subject to the curse of Genesis 3:17 and constantly under the sentence of eternal death.

So how did man come to have such a bad relationship with God? We know from John 3:1-8 that man's problem is radical. It is, in fact, congenital. This is the meaning of John 3:6. "That which is born of the flesh is flesh" says Jesus, so the whole problem stems from where we come from and the meaning of the word "flesh" in John 3 is "carnality". This means that sin has its locus in the heart of man, the absolute centre of his being. We don't sin because we have a problem; we sin because we *are* a problem. And so man's greatest need, a need that dwarfs all others, is to be reconciled to God.

So when we say that the natural man cannot please God we are talking about a moral inability, not a physical inability. When people reject Christ in the gospel it is not as though they really want to accept him but find that something prevents them. At best they are simply not interested and, at worst, openly hostile. John tells us in John 3:19-21 that there is really only one reason why people reject Christ in the gospel, and that is because they love darkness (sin) and hate the light (Christ).

This raises the problem of free will. Does this radical view of sin exclude free will and turn us all into pre-programmed robots? It all depends on how we define the word “free”. We can only will what we want. For example, a horse has no desire for meat, being a herbivore by nature. So a horse can never *want* to eat meat. The natural man has no desire for God, being a God hater by nature so he can never want to love God. In objection to this, it has been argued that there are times when we have to make decisions that are contrary to our desires. For example, we can be forced at gunpoint to hand over our money. But this is not a violation of the rule because in this case we say that our desire to live trumps our desire to hang on to our money. So the things we will are always according to our strongest desire. With the natural man, it is always a *no brainer* as to whether he will accept Christ in the gospel or remain in his sin because his love of sin will always trump any possibility of coming to Christ. I say "possibility" because, in this case, we could compare his struggle to a one sided game of tug-of-war!

So does the natural man have free will? To the extent that he is free to choose what he wants (desires) the answer is yes. But to the extent that he cannot generate a desire for God in his own heart, the answer is no. It all depends on how we look at it. We could say that although the natural man has free will he doesn’t have free want.

So what hope is there for the natural man? Of himself he is both helpless and hopeless. It is bad enough to want to change and be unable to, but to lack all desire for change in the first place makes change depressingly impossible. We can try to rescue a drowning man but if he is intent on drowning himself

then he will indeed perish. Man’s condition is beyond hopeless; it is tragic and insanely self-immolating. After God, his own worst enemy is himself. I say "after God" because it is only God who can cast the soul into hell which is a fate much worse than death.

Returning to the story of the rich young ruler[7] who comes to Jesus with the question,

> And, behold, one came and said unto him, Good Master, what good thing shall I do, that I may have eternal life?

(Matthew 19:16-26) we read that after having his concept of goodness challenged he goes away “grieving”. Being asked to sell all of his property and to give the money to the poor was certainly a big ask. Even the disciples were shocked by the difficulty of it. So they asked,

> Who then can be saved?

Jesus concludes,

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7 The story of the Rich Young Ruler in Mark 10:17 -27 could give the impression that the young man was deeply grieved over his inability to follow Christ; however, Jesus' challenge to his concept of the "good" indicates that he had no true understanding of goodness at all. As far as he was concerned he was already "good" but lacked something he knew not what. And to value his property above eternal life only proved that he had no concept of eternal life either. He was the merchant of fine pearls who could not tell a good pearl from a dud!

> With men this is impossible; but with God all things are possible.

In other words, given man's radical fallenness into sin, it is impossible for him to accept the gospel offer. But there is a work around, a divine work around, a sovereign and incomprehensibly gracious work around, which leads us to our next chapter.

Questions

1. What does it mean to be "dead in sin"?
2. How do we reconcile the biblical view of fallen man with the scores of unbelievers we know as fair, kind and friendly people?
3. Is it possible for fallen man to be religious? Explain.
4. What does it mean to be radically sinful?
5. What does John 3:19-21 tell us about the condition of fallen man?

2. The Plan

The bible is clear that God has a plan to save men. In fact, the bible from Genesis to Revelation is about that plan. We know that God is not capricious; God plans everything. He does not wake up one morning and decide to do this or that. God knows exactly what he will do tomorrow, next week, next year and to

eternity. Not only are God's plans ontologically necessary[8], they are also perfect and therefore immutable. There is no plan B with God for he is not contingent upon his creatures. Were it not so then he would not be God, and the salvation of men is no exception to this rule.

One of the clearest passages in the New Testament that testifies to this plan is the parable of the good shepherd in John 10. Jesus is the good shepherd and we learn that the good shepherd calls his own sheep by name (v.3) and leads them out to pasture. That he calls them by name is significant because it particularises the call. He does not call them generally and then leave it up to them to follow. The call is both personal, particular and effectual.

What is also clear from this parable is that not all the sheep are his sheep. There are those who are his and those who are not, otherwise the use of the first person possessive "my" becomes redundant. And the good shepherd leads his sheep to "pasture". We also learn that the good shepherd (Jesus) must defend the sheep against predators and in the process lay down his life for the sheep. This is a clear reference to his atoning death and although the definite article is used here instead of the possessive pronoun ("*the* sheep") the context demands that the sheep for whom he lays down his life are *his* sheep, but we will revisit that again later.

Probably the most interesting part of John 10 is Jesus' confrontation with the Jews in verses 24 – 26.

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8 Ontology is the study of being. God's propensity to plan follows from his omniscience and omnipotence which are attributes of his being.

> 24 Then came the Jews round about him, and said unto him, How long dost thou make us to doubt? If thou be the Christ, tell us plainly. 25 Jesus answered them, I told you, and ye believed not: the works that I do in my Father's name, they bear witness of me. 26 But ye believe not, because ye are not of my sheep, as I said unto you.

In verse 26 Jesus explains the disbelief on the part of the Jews as a result of not being among his sheep. We need to stop here for a moment and think. Hasn’t Jesus got this back to front? Are not people excluded from the fold because they lack faith? Or conversely, to become his sheep are we not to simply believe? But this is not what Jesus says; the Greek is quite plain. Belief is a *result* of being his sheep. It’s important that we get the order right if we are to understand the gospel. Being the sheep of Christ is a necessary and even sufficient condition in order to believe. In saving his sheep the good shepherd must first enable them to follow him, so divine possession is logically prior to human acceptance. It is unfortunate that in embracing this position we separate ourselves from most of the modern evangelical church, but at the same time we commit ourselves to a much better gospel, a gospel that takes the impotence of fallen man seriously and that looks to the Holy Spirit for its power.

In verse 29 Jesus tells us that it was the Father who gave him the sheep. So the sheep became his not because they decided to follow him. We have already seen that they cannot, of their own accord, choose Jesus; but the Father can choose them and make whatever changes are necessary for them to respond.

So when did Jesus acquire his sheep? We have already seen that God (the Father) plans everything. In Ephesians 1:4 Paul tells us that God chose us *in Christ* "before the foundation of the world". This is what we call the “Covenant of Redemption”, which is a covenant between the Father and the Son. The Father chooses some, unconditionally, out of a fallen race of humanity and gives them to the Son who agrees to redeem them. Now we see a plan beginning to unfold.

So how important is the divine initiative to the work of salvation? It is logically necessary if we take the radical fallenness of the natural man into account. And if we can agree that we are morally passive to the point of death then we must agree that God must make the first move if anyone is to be saved. This makes God a complete saviour; indeed, the very “author and finisher of our faith” (Hebrews 12:2). So it should be no surprise that God planned every step and that even history unfolds according to this plan.

Questions

1. If God didn’t plan what implications would this have concerning his character?
2. What is the Covenant of Redemption?

3. What is wrong with telling someone that they must believe in Jesus in order to become his sheep?
4. What aspect of man's fallenness makes the divine initiative in salvation necessary?

3. The Execution

The work of salvation is a work not just of the Father but also of the Son and the Holy Spirit. These three persons of the trinity are in an *economic* relationship, i.e., they work together in achieving the work of salvation. We could summarise that relationship as follows: The Father plans, the Son executes and the Holy Spirit applies. This chapter is about the saving work of the Son who is the executor of the plan. John tells us in his gospel, chapter 3:16,

> For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.

In this verse we see the initiative of the Father and the obedient response of the Son. It is at the Father's behest that the Son comes into the world. The purpose is that "whoever believes in him", ie., the Son, has eternal life.

Throughout the entire gospel of John we see many references to the subordination of Jesus to his Father. In John 6:38 Jesus says, "For I came down from heaven, not to do mine own will, but the will of him that sent me." This "will" to which Jesus refers is the plan we have been talking about in the previous

chapter. So the public ministry of Jesus is a single minded dedication to the execution of that plan.

If we now return to John 10 we see that part of that plan has already been executed before Jesus arrives. The Father gave some of fallen mankind to the Son and the Son agreed to save them, beginning with his incarnation and concluding with his ascension. We also know that from all eternity Jesus has been given so many “sheep” which he calls “by name” and who follow him. And because his atoning death is the climax of his public ministry we need to understand exactly what that death was about.

The most common view is that Jesus went to the cross to atone for the sins of everybody, i.e., every man, woman and child who has ever lived upon the earth. This view, called the universal atonement view, has done much to shape the gospel of the modern evangelical church. As a result the gospel has been condensed down to the mantra "Jesus has died for your sins". The problem, of course, is that this completely ignores the Father’s plan. We saw from John 10 that Jesus, the good shepherd, lays down his life for *his* sheep. He does not lay down his life for all sheep.

Can Jesus change the plan? We know from chapter 1 that God’s plans are immutable. For Jesus to change the plan and decide to die for everyone constitutes a serious deviation. It is serious because it is a clear overreach of what the Father has given him and involves a grab for sheep that are not rightfully his. It also constitutes a failure on the part of Jesus to faithfully execute the plan agreed to in the covenant of redemption. To take this

further, if this were possible (and we know it isn't!) it would create a serious cleavage within the holy Trinity itself. The Father wants only some to be saved, the Son wants all to be saved, and the Holy Spirit is the meat in the sandwich!

It is not for us to question the integrity of the Father in choosing only some. We can only bow before such passages as Romans 9 and say with Abraham, "Shall not the judge of all the earth do right?" (Genesis 18:25). So a proper understanding of the atonement is important if we want to get the gospel right. If we understand the role of Jesus as executor of the Father's plan we know that his mission was to save those whom the Father gave him before the foundation of the world. So what effect should this have on our gospel?

John 3:16, re-stated below, is often called the gospel in a verse, a close examination of which will yield some surprising insights.

> For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.

The preposition "in" (Greek - eis) implies a relationship. It is one thing to believe someone but another to believe *in* them. To believe in someone is to put one's faith in them to do what they undertake. It implies a relationship of trust. To simply believe that Jesus died for your sins is an intellectual assent to what is purported to be an historical fact. No relationship is implied. But as we saw in chapter 1 man's root problem is not an intellectual one. He is not condemned because he doesn't know

something. He is condemned because he is in a toxic relationship with God. So when we ask people to believe *in* Jesus we are calling them into a different relationship altogether, a relationship of trust. To make that possible we have to teach them about Jesus, his person and work, which are the focus of the gospel message.

Just as Adam did not act merely on his own behalf in the Garden of Eden[9], Jesus did not act on his own behalf throughout his earthly ministry, and particularly not on the cross. It was there that he died as a representative of his people. This was a *substitutionary* atonement. So Paul could say in Romans 6 that when he died *we* died and it was *our* sins that were paid for by his death (See also Isaiah 53:4-6; Romans 5:6 et. al). We must not, however, let a limited atonement diminish the atoning *value* of that death. The value is not determined by the number of its beneficiaries but by the identity of the benefactor. Jesus continued to be the perfectly holy Son of God on the cross which made his death infinitely valuable. Even if he had died for all mankind his death would have been sufficient for all. But that, of course, was not the plan.

So the gospel is not “Jesus has died for your sins”. While this is true for some, it is not true for all. We simply don’t know who the elect are when preaching the gospel, and neither do we need to know. The great commission as given in Matthew 28:16 -20 is to “make disciples” and not merely intellectual

9 Although not expanded upon here, Adam did not act purely on his own behalf in the Garden of Eden but also on behalf of his entire progeny. Not only did that progeny inherit his sinful nature because of natural generation but also his guilt because of legal representation. It is this sin complex that must be overcome by the gospel (See Romans 5:12-21).

believers. As a Roman Catholic many years ago I believed that Jesus died for my sins but my relationship with God was toxic. I was at enmity with him although I didn't know it at the time. It wasn't until I put my trust in Jesus that my life changed.

Questions

1. Explain the economic relationship within the Trinity.
2. What implications concerning the Trinity would follow if Jesus decided to alter the plan of salvation? Explain.
3. What is wrong with telling an unbeliever that Jesus has died for his/her sins?
4. Explain the significance of the preposition "in" in John 3:16.
5. Explain *substitutionary atonement.*
6. How would you counter the argument that a limited atonement limits the love and power of Christ's death?

4. The Application

So now we come to the matter of application and our concern here is with the question: how does the gospel bring about the sort of change that makes it possible for man to be reconciled to God? In chapter 1 we saw that the natural man cannot, by nature, make even the smallest step toward God. Any change therefore cannot come from within but must come from without. This makes it wholly supernatural. In other words, fallen man needs to be rescued. Here is where we enter the domain of the Holy Spirit, the divine perfecter of the work of salvation.

When Jesus was about to ascend to the right hand of the Father, Luke records in Acts 1:4 and 8,

> 4 For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.
>
> 8 But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.

Although the book of Acts is often referred to as the Acts of the Apostles, we could just as easily call it the Acts of the Holy Spirit for wherever the apostles went the Holy Spirit also went and whatever power they had was not their own but came from the Holy Spirit. To understand how the Holy Spirit works we first must understand that the Spirit always works in, with, and through the Word. They are never separate[10]. In fact, they are so closely associated that Peter could say in 1 Peter 1:22-23,

> 22 Seeing ye have purified your souls in obeying the truth through the Spirit unto unfeigned love of the brethren, see that ye love one another with a pure heart fervently: 23 Being born again, not of

10 That being said, we also know that in cases where it is impossible for people to believe in Christ such as small children and those with severe intellectual disabilities such people are not beyond the power of God to save. For the purpose of this book it is assumed that our hearers are not in these categories.

> corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever.

Could the Holy Spirit have converted people without the word? Of course! after all, he is God. But that's not his chosen method and although that might be preferable for us, it is not in the plan. In John 16:13 Jesus refers to the Holy Spirit as the "Spirit of Truth" and we know that it was the Holy Spirit who inspired the writers of all 66 books of the bible. For this book to have any impact at all on sinful man there must come a profound change within the hearts of its readers. This change we call *regeneration*, sometimes referred to as "being born again".

For an in-depth understanding of this process we turn to John 3:1-8.

> 1 There was a man of the Pharisees, named Nicodemus, a ruler of the Jews: 2 The same came to Jesus by night, and said unto him, Rabbi, we know that thou art a teacher come from God: for no man can do these miracles that thou doest, except God be with him. 3 Jesus answered and said unto him, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born again, he cannot see the kingdom of God.
> 4 Nicodemus saith unto him, How can a man be born when he is old? can he enter the second time into his mother's womb, and be born? 5 Jesus answered, Verily, verily, I say unto thee, Except a man be born of water and of the Spirit, he cannot enter into the kingdom of God. 6 That which is born of the flesh is flesh; and that which is born of

> the Spirit is spirit. 7 Marvel not that I said unto thee, Ye must be born again. 8 The wind bloweth where it listeth, and thou hearest the sound thereof, but canst not tell whence it cometh, and whither it goeth: so is every one that is born of the Spirit.

There are a number of things which this passage teaches us about regeneration.

1. **It is a work of the Holy Spirit**. The "wind" (πνεῦμα) in John 3 is a play on words for in the Greek it also means *spirit*.

2. **It is a necessary prerequisite of salvation**. Twice in this passage Jesus conditions entry into the kingdom on regeneration.

3. **It is a hidden work**. Just as we cannot see the wind, neither can we see the Holy Spirit or his internal operation.

4. **It is never without evidence**. Despite the lack of visibility we are always aware of his work. This is the "sound" of the wind in John 3.

5. **It is a spiritual change**. Jesus says that regeneration is "of water and of the Spirit". As a Pharisee Nicodemus understood that the reference to water pointed to a clean start. So Jesus says, in effect, that we must come from something clean and that the Holy Spirit is the agent of that gestation.

6. **It is a sovereign work**. Jesus says, "The wind bloweth where it listeth". We have no way of knowing where or when

the Holy Spirit will act. This explains why preaching must be indiscriminate.

7. **It was taught in the Old Testament**. Jesus gently rebukes Nicodemus for not knowing about it. (See verse 10).

When we communicate the gospel we are catering to the Holy Spirit; i.e., we are giving the Holy Spirit what he needs to convert the soul. Since he is the Spirit of Truth, we must concern ourselves with a truthful, i.e., accurate, gospel. This means that there must be sufficient truth in our gospel in order to change one who is rebellious in nature to one who actually wants to serve God. This transformation is no less radical than the raising of a dead body to life; indeed, it is called the first resurrection in Revelation 20:5-6; See also Ezekiel 37:1-14.

The question arises as to exactly when regeneration occurs within the sequence of events leading up to conversion? When we consider the many different examples of conversion within the New Testament what soon becomes apparent is the uniqueness of each instance. There are really no two the same. Whether it be the Woman of Samaria or Zacchaeus the tax collector or the thief on the cross, Jesus' approach is different every time. But we know from John 3 that they all have one thing in common: regeneration *precedes* faith and repentance. That is a moral necessity and because the agent is the Holy Spirit we must leave that part up to him to perform when, how and in whom he so chooses.

The trend today is to equate regeneration with coming to Christ. This denies the necessity of regeneration as the vital

prerequisite of faith and repentance. If we follow this line of thinking repentance and faith are seen as natural responses to the gospel; natural because they can be performed by the natural man. It is not inconsequential that this is also seen as the result of a decision. So we *decide* to be regenerated. But this contradicts what Jesus says in John 3:1-8, "The wind (Spirit) blows wherever it pleases" (Verse 8). It is no wonder, then, that decisionism is the dominant method of evangelism in many evangelical churches today.

I can remember when I was a young Christian counselling new converts at an outreach rally. A man came forward and wanted to be "a Christian" but he remained unconvinced by the arguments. In fact, there were very few arguments, just a video on the rapture and the dangers of being left behind! Anxious to usher him into the kingdom I told him to simply believe and all would be well. "You can decide to believe" I told him. This was no different from telling him to rebirth himself! (For an illustrative explanation of Regeneration see the Appendix on page 46.)

From chapter 1 we know that regeneration is a *radical*[11] change. The change gives us a desire for God, something impossible to autogenerate. But this desire does not materialise in a vacuum. Beside the gospel, there are two things the unbeliever must come to know before he can embrace Christ for salvation. He must come to know himself and he must come to know God. This is what the Holy Spirit needs in order to bring him to an intelligent faith in Christ. To understand why these are important we will consider them separately.

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11 From the Latin: *radix* - root.

Knowing himself. If we want the unbeliever to embrace Christ for salvation we must bring him to the point of self-despair. Self-despair is necessary for saving faith because without it we cannot trust in Christ *alone* for salvation. Trusting in Christ *alone* is a critical feature of saving faith and is the burden of Paul's letter to the Galatians.

The self-despair necessary for saving faith can only come if the unbeliever agrees with the biblical diagnosis of his condition. We must not hold back on this as many churches do today in the name of the "seeker sensitive" approach. In this approach the hard truths of Ephesians 2, John 3 and Romans 3 are avoided in order not to discourage "seekers" from returning. So sin is soft peddled and, in some cases, left out altogether being substituted by such things as poor health, low self esteem and un-fulfilment. But there are two fatal errors in this approach:

1. *The bible knows nothing of seekers* (Romans 3:11). As we discovered in chapter 1 the unbeliever is not a seeker until he is regenerated, at which time he is well on the way to conversion anyway.

2. *The role of the Holy Spirit to regenerate does not include special revelation* to the hearer about the state of his soul. That has to come from the scriptures. What regeneration does is to *enable* the hearer to accept the biblical diagnosis.

After sovereign grace, this is probably the most difficult truth to get across to many evangelical preachers today. Desperate for an audience, they bend over backwards not to offend their

hearers but what is not realised is that the gospel is, by its very nature, a stumbling block to the unregenerate. Trying to make the gospel attractive to such only empties it of its suitability for the Holy Spirit to work with. Remember, the Holy Spirit works with the Word. Truncate the word and you truncate the saving power of the Holy Spirit. Getting them back each week achieves nothing if they get the same watered down diatribe every time.

Knowing God.
Again, if we want the unbeliever to embrace Jesus for salvation we need to bring him to the conviction that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of the living God and saviour of all who come to him in faith. As mentioned earlier, saving faith is not a blind leap in the dark. We are not going to entrust our souls to one about whom we know nothing. To do that would actually be quite foolish and God is not the father of fools. So we need to show the unbeliever, from the scriptures, who Jesus is. This is the purpose of the gospels. John articulates this purpose in John 20:30-31 where he says,

> 30 And many other signs truly did Jesus in the presence of his disciples, which are not written in this book: 31 But these are written, that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God; and that believing ye might have life through his name.

Like self-knowledge, God-knowledge is not given mystically by the Holy Spirit but must come from the scriptures. It is the Spirit's role to apply this knowledge to the heart.

It is imperative that the convert be convinced of the power of Jesus to forgive his sins; after all, there is a lot riding on the faith that he will eventually put in Jesus. For Jesus to forgive sins he must be God. Sin is a debt, we are the debtors and God is the creditor. This is in accord with a God-focused definition of sin. The miracles are designed to convince us of Jesus' divinity. Other defining moments such as the virgin birth, the crucifixion, and the resurrection should always have special place in demonstrating this. Concerning the resurrection we need to remember that, following the ascension of Jesus, the apostles were first and foremost eye witnesses of his resurrection, and although we do not qualify in such terms today the Holy Spirit is more than capable of convincing our hearers of these vital truths. And the further we delve into the gospel and how it works the more we see just how much we depend upon the Holy Spirit to get the job done. So the indispensability of the Holy Spirit's work must remain uppermost in our minds throughout the entire presentation of the gospel. This cannot be emphasised enough.

Also of importance is the holiness of God. This means that God hates sin every bit as much as he loves righteousness. For God to wink at sin would be to compromise his own character. As an example of this principle, let's say you prized honesty in people even at the cost of sensitivity. Would you be indifferent toward someone who had a reputation for lying? Of course you wouldn't! In other words, to love something is to hate its opposite. This is why God cannot tolerate sin and will always exact a price for it. Fortunately that price was paid by his Son when he took upon himself the sins of his people.

Finally, there is a reciprocal effect between knowing ourselves and knowing God. The more we strengthen the one the more we enhance the other. The more we know ourselves the more we appreciate the grace of God; the more we know God the more we know our sin and our need for salvation.

Questions

1. Critique the view that the Holy Spirit converts people by his ability to persuade them to come to Christ.
2. What seven things do we learn from John 3:1-8?
3. Critique the view that people are regenerated by putting their faith in Christ.
4. What two things must the unbeliever come to know before he can embrace Christ for salvation?

5. Putting It All Together

So how do we preach a gospel that relies on the Holy Spirit and maintains its cutting edge intact? If our anthropology of fallen man is correct we will have no trouble in accepting the necessity of the divine initiative in the plan of salvation. We will not be shocked that many are passed by in the election process but rather amazed that any are chosen at all. The sinful nature as we have defined it precludes any kind of reward or preference based on inherent virtue in the sinner. "As it is written, There is none righteous, no, not one: " says Paul in Romans 3:10.

That God has planned the work of redemption "before the foundation of the world" (Ephesians 1:4) shouldn't surprise us either as planning is integral to the very nature of an omniscient and omnipotent God. The executorial function of the Son is deeply rooted in the economic hierarchy of the Trinity (not to be confused with an *ontological* hierarchy[12]) and is foundational to the particularity of his atoning death. The sovereign application of that atonement by the Holy Spirit to the heirs of salvation in time fits perfectly with the role of the divine Perfecter within that same economic hierarchy.

All attempts to "improve" this amazing symphony by some form of de-particularisation has invariably distorted the gospel into one misshapen form or another, the effect of which has left us with a declawed gospel that either saves nobody or saves in spite of itself. However, a deliberate distortion is not the only way to emasculate the gospel; another, and equally popular way, is to ignore its dependence upon biblical truth. There is so much left out of the popular gospel that it is almost impossible for the Holy Spirit to do anything with it. The rise of post-modernism and its influence upon the churches has bred a certain contempt for serious theology that has morphed sermons into motivational talks. And Neo-Pentecostalism with its emphasis upon mystical guidance has provided fertile ground for this post-modernist onslaught.

In order to clarify the sort of transformation we can expect from a true conversion, lets compare both sets of characteristics in a juxtaposition.

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12 A hierarchy based on superiority of being.

Unbeliever		***Believer***
Dead in sin; following the course of this world; following the devil; living in the passions of his flesh; fulfilling lustful desires; by nature a child of wrath; hating Jesus; loving sin and ignorance; unrighteous; without understanding; lacking all desire for God; worthless to God; never doing good; foul mouthed; lying; verbally poisonous; murderous; destructive; trouble making; Godless.		Alive together with Christ; raised up and seated with Christ in the heavens; saved from the judicial consequences of sin; God's workmanship; able to do good works; **trusting in Christ alone for salvation; convicted of sin against God; loving God; submitting to Christ as Lord, spiritually fruitful, respecting the bible.**

See Ephesians 2:1-10, John 3:1-21, and Romans 3:9-26

So let's consider the steps needed in order to take our hearer from the unconverted state (described on the left) to the converted state (described on the right). The characteristics in bold are the behaviours that we can, in tandem with the Holy Spirit, bring to pass through the teaching of biblical truth. Notice that I haven't included regeneration because regeneration is what we call a monergism, i.e., an exclusively singular work of the Holy Spirit. Our concern, then, is with the synergisms, i.e., the things we do in tandem with the Holy Spirit.

Step 1. Conviction of sin.

The only way to come to Christ that results in salvation is to come for forgiveness of sin. If we come to him for healing or financial security or good self-esteem or success in business we will not get salvation or any of its accompanying blessings. This is patently obvious when we consider how clear the New Testament is on the purpose of the crucifixion. It is not as though God doesn't care about temporal well-being; he does. But he sacrifices his Son in order to deal with man’s greatest problem and, indeed, the root cause of all of his problems: sin.

So conviction of sin against God is what must drive the unbeliever to Christ. I emphasise "against God" because the type of repentance we are looking for is a turning from rebellion against God to submission to his supreme authority. This is what I call "God-ward repentance" and it is the only repentance that works in the gospel. There is a God-less repentance for miss deeds that has nothing to do with gospel repentance, and Judas was a good example of that. He was grieved that he had betrayed innocent blood (Matthew 27:4) but he was not grieved that he was complicit in the murder of the Son of God. There is a world of difference here.

The Holy Spirit, who is essential in generating this conviction in the heart, will not do this in a vacuum. So the unbeliever has to come to know certain things about himself and these things are contained in such passages as Ephesians 2:1-3, John 3:19-21, and Romans 3:9-18. These passages teach us that he is naturally dead in sin, hates God and is devoid of all righteousness.

There will be a strong temptation to avoid these passages for fear of turning our hearers away, but it doesn't do the unbeliever any favours to keep from him the hard facts of his condition. This is where some commitment given before the start of the presentation can help to keep the hearer listening. Also, emphasise that the hard sayings are not yours per se, but God's. The bottom line here is that you are relying on the Holy Spirit to bring about the conviction of sin *necessary for conversion* and this requires a certain amount of faith on your part.

We should be able to see by now that the approach where we assure the unbeliever that God loves him and has a wonderful plan for his life puts the brakes on any attempt to lead him to a conviction of sin. We want his alarm bells to ring; this is not the time for warm fuzzy feelings. This also means warning him of the consequences of not believing. Passages such as Matthew 13:36-43 are good examples of these warnings.

Step 2. Trust in Christ alone for salvation

So we need to ask: what does the unbeliever need to know about Jesus in order to be able to do this? Let's consider it:

(a) Jesus is Divine.

We need to talk about the Lord Jesus Christ as the only solution to the problem of sin so that the unbeliever will place all of his trust in Jesus to save him. If he has a conviction of sin against God then he will want God to forgive him. So he needs to know that Christ is God. It's no good asking your brother to forgive a debt that you happen to owe your sister. Coming to Jesus then for forgiveness of sin is coming to the right person.

There are important events in the gospels that reveal the heavenly origin and divine identity of Jesus not the least of which is his virgin birth recorded in Luke 1 and 2. And, of course, there are the miracles. It doesn't really matter which ones, whether it is the calming of the storm or the raising of Lazarus; they all reveal the divine nature of Jesus.

(b) Jesus came to save the lost.

He needs to know *why* Jesus came in the first place. In Luke 19:9-10 we read,

> 9 And Jesus said unto him, This day is salvation come to this house, forsomuch as he also is a son of Abraham. 10 For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost.

And, of course, there is also John 3:16.

(c) Jesus died as our substitute.

Next, we tell him what the death of Jesus was about. Romans 5:6-8 and 6:23.

> 5:6-8 For when we were yet without strength, in due time Christ died for the ungodly. For scarcely for a righteous man will one die: yet peradventure for a good man some would even dare to die. But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us.
>
> 6:23 For the wages of sin is death; but the gift of God is eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

Verse 8 deserves special attention here because it defines the death of Jesus in terms of God's love. Point out to him that in the giving of his only begotten son God could not have loved his people more. This is the point of John 15:13,

> Greater love hath no man than this, that a man lay down his life for his friends.

It takes time for the profundity of this love to sink into the soul but when it does it is nothing less than transformative. That said, you must also point out that such love is only available *in Christ* and having the hearer in Christ is the goal of this whole exercise. It is dead easy to laps, almost unconsciously, into universalism when presenting the gospel. But if you want your hearer to recognise the great value of being in Christ you will avoid universalism like the plague.

Romans 5:6-8 is Paul’s address to the *Christians* of the Roman church and not to just anybody. It was appropriate, therefore, to tell them that Christ has died for them. So when you use Romans 5:6-8 don’t forget to point out the context. The saying is worth remembering, “A text out of context is a pretext.”

(d) Jesus rose from the dead.

Because Jesus is the Saviour of others your hearer needs to know that Jesus was able to save himself from death; so the resurrection of Jesus is vital and deserves special attention. We must remember that the task of the apostles throughout Acts was to be eye witnesses of the resurrection of Jesus. In the minds of the first century Jew, Jesus' resurrection was absolutely determinative of who and what he was. So it is no surprise that the central theme in Peter's first sermon to the Jews at Pentecost was the bodily resurrection of Jesus (Acts 2:22-36). We need to explain that Jesus has two natures, divine and human. It was the human nature that died and it was the divine nature that raised the human nature from the grave.

(e) Jesus ascended to the right hand of the Father.

The unbeliever also needs to know that Jesus ascended to the right hand of the Father forty days after his resurrection where he now reigns as king of kings and lord of lords. Indeed, it is to this exalted Christ that they are now being asked to submit.

Acts 1:9

> And when he had spoken these things, while they beheld, he was taken up; and a cloud received him out of their sight.

Philippians 2:9-10

> 9 Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him, and given him a name which is above every name:
> 10 That at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, and things under the earth;

(f) Jesus will return.

Last, but not least, we need to tell him that Jesus will return. We get this from such passages as:

John 14:1-3

> 1 Let not your heart be troubled: ye believe in God, believe also in me. 2 In my Father's house are many mansions: if it were not so, I would have told you. I go to prepare a place for you. 3 And if I go and prepare a place for you, I will come again, and receive you unto myself; that where I am, there ye may be also.

Acts 1:11

> Which also said, Ye men of Galilee, why stand ye gazing up into heaven? this same Jesus, which is taken up from you into heaven, shall so come in like manner as ye have seen him go into heaven.

So all of these passages enable us, intelligently, to trust in Jesus for salvation. They are his messianic credentials.

Step 3. Submission to Christ as Lord

This is the third step that needs to be taken for a genuine conversion to occur. We saw in the first step that conviction of sin against God was an essential ingredient of a true conversion. No conviction means no repentance, and no repentance means no conversion. Repentance is what we do about conviction. It is a natural consequence of conviction. It is also the *irresistible* component of sovereign grace. In repentance we turn from sin to righteousness, rebellion to submission. Repentance is essentially a change of attitude for which the Greek word is *μετάνοια* (*metanoia)* meaning literally a *change of mind*. We now agree with God that our former lives were rebellious and that we now need to embrace Jesus as Lord. Again, we refer to Ephesians 2:9-10:

> 9 Not of works, lest any man should boast.

> 10 For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works, which God hath before ordained that we should walk in them.

It is important to note here that we don't *make* Jesus Lord contrary to the lyrics of some modern hymns; he is already Lord and we submit to him as such.

Step 4. Respecting the Bible

An unfortunate trend in the churches today is to divide Christ from his word. Instead of submitting to Christ so many end up submitting to the leadings and impulses of the "Spirit" within them. I put the word "Spirit" in quotes because this is not how the Holy Spirit works. We have already seen that the Holy Spirit always works in, with and through the word of God but many evangelicals are being mistakenly guided by what they believe to be the "leadings" of the Holy Spirit. We've all heard it, "I felt led to do this" or "God told me to do that." Let me make it abundantly clear that this type of guidance has nothing to do with the Holy Spirit or with submission to Christ. We submit to the Christ *OF* the bible when we submit to Christ *IN* the bible.

All of this means that the true believer will have a reverence for scripture. It is put there by the Holy Spirit and is part of the conversion package. This is not to say that we should not point out the divine origin of the bible to the unbeliever. Some relevant texts are:

1 Corinthians 2:10-13

10 But God hath revealed them unto us by his Spirit: for the Spirit searcheth all things, yea, the deep things of God.

11 For what man knoweth the things of a man, save the spirit of man which is in him? even so the things of God knoweth no man, but the Spirit of God.

12 Now we have received, not the spirit of the world, but the spirit which is of God; that we might know the things that are freely given to us of God. 13 Which things also we speak, not in the words which man's wisdom teacheth, but which the Holy Ghost teacheth; comparing spiritual things with spiritual.

2 Timothy 3:16-17

16 All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: 17 That the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works.

Step 5. Counting the Cost

Submission to Christ comes at a cost. It means a radical change of lifestyle. Your unsaved friends won't like it. Your unsaved family won't like it. Your unsaved employer won't like it. Submitting to Christ could cost you your job, your marriage, your popularity, your standing in the local community, and even your life in some cases. You need to point that out to the unbeliever. Jesus warns potential believers in the following terms:

Luke 14:25-33

> 25 And there went great multitudes with him: and
> he turned, and said unto them, 26 If any man come
> to me, and hate not his father, and mother, and
> wife, and children, and brethren, and sisters, yea,
> and his own life also, he cannot be my disciple.
> 27 And whosoever doth not bear his cross, and
> come after me, cannot be my disciple. 28 For
> which of you, intending to build a tower, sitteth not
> down first, and counteth the cost, whether he have
> sufficient to finish it? 29 Lest haply, after he hath
> laid the foundation, and is not able to finish it, all
> that behold it begin to mock him, 30 Saying, This
> man began to build, and was not able to finish.
> 31 Or what king, going to make war against
> another king, sitteth not down first, and consulteth
> whether he be able with ten thousand to meet him
> that cometh against him with twenty thousand?
> 32 Or else, while the other is yet a great way off, he

> sendeth an ambassage, and desireth conditions of peace. 33 So likewise, whosoever he be of you that forsaketh not all that he hath, he cannot be my disciple.

We could get the impression that, after weighing the pros and cons, the unbeliever decides that becoming a Christian is not in his best interest; however, if we have understood the dynamics of regeneration, we will also know that becoming a Christian is not a cold blooded exercise in weighing pros and cons but a capitulation to the irresistible force of the Father who *draws*[13] us to Christ (See John 6:44). Rejection at this point only means that the unbeliever has not been so drawn.

Counting the cost is another step that is tempting to leave out. We are naturally anxious to persuade the hearer into the kingdom and recoil at the prospect of putting a stumbling block before him. But if Jesus urged his hearers to count the cost of discipleship then it is incumbent on us to do the same. And if this is what he wants then we know that the Holy Spirit will use it, even if only to sort out the goats from the sheep.

Step 6. The Sinner's Prayer?

I put this as a question as it is traditional but not savingly necessary to pray with the new convert at the end of the presentation. There is nothing wrong with this but we need to be cautious about a number of things:

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13 The Greek word for "draw" here is ἑλκύσῃ, also used to draw water from a well.

(i) It is not our role to give assurance of salvation simply on the basis of a verbal commitment. One important sign of a true conversion is perseverance. In 1 John 2:19 we read,

> 19 They went out from us, but they were not of us; for if they had been of us, they would no doubt have continued with us: but they went out, that they might be made manifest that they were not all of us.

(ii) Of equal importance is the evidence of the Holy Spirit given in Galatians 5:22-23:

> 22 But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, faith,
> 23 Meekness, temperance: against such there is no law.

But these are not obvious in the short term, particularly perseverance; so we leave it to the Holy Spirit to manifest his presence in time. That is not to say that the new convert himself cannot be assured of his own conversion; he can be, which is a good thing. But past experience of false conversions makes it prudent for us to reserve judgement for another time.

(iii) Commonly included in the sinner's prayer is an invitation for Jesus to enter our hearts. But this is not how people are saved. The Holy Spirit enters us at the point of regeneration concerning which we know not how or when. Do we invite him in? Definitely not! It would be more accurate to say that he

kicks the door in and then performs a big cleanup. By the time we want him in our hearts he is already there.

Questions

1. Outline the six steps involved in conversion.
2. Explain the meaning of the words *monergism* and *synergism* and give theological examples of each.
3. What is wrong with the following views:
    a) Becoming a Christian is to invite Jesus into our hearts.
    b) We can skip the six steps and ask people to “just do it”, making faith an irrational leap

6. Conclusion

We need to be clear that becoming a Christian is no leap in the dark. God is not irrational and neither is his gospel. Let's read 1 Peter 3:15.

1 Peter 3:15

> But sanctify the Lord God in your hearts: and be ready always to give an answer to every man that asketh you a reason of the hope that is in you with meekness and fear:

The assumption here is that we have a reason for our hope which is intelligible and able to be articulated. If the gospel

makes no sense to you then you have good reason to be worried. But if it does make sense and your faith is real then you are qualified to explain that gospel to others, always relying, of course, upon the Holy Spirit. You must not worry about the hard words of scripture. They not only don't get in the way, they *are* the way. Avoiding them disempowers the Holy Spirit who can only work with the truth. The more we get to know the gospel the more incredible a story it is and, paradoxically, the more we will want to share it with others.

What about the divine initiative? Should we leave this out of the gospel presentation? Some would argue that as strong meat it should not be given to spiritual babes; however, Jesus didn't hide it from Nicodemus, an unconverted Pharisee and neither did he avoid it when speaking to the 5,000 following the multiplication of bread and fish (John 6:52-59). In the case of Nicodemus (John 3:1-8) Jesus makes it clear that his hope lies not in any ability to save himself but in the sovereign and gracious work of the Holy Spirit. It was Nicodemus's self-righteousness as a Pharisee that made the divine initiative a necessary part of the conversation. While he laboured under the fatal belief that he could save himself he remained light years away from the kingdom. That belief had to be demolished and there was no better way to do it than to lay before him the depths of his depravity and the sovereign power of the Holy Spirit who alone can remove that depravity.

It is worth noting that the information Jesus gives Nicodemus was not something Nicodemus could act upon. We know he couldn't rebirth himself. So what was the point of it all? The only way we can make sense of Jesus' method is to say that he

was catering to the Holy Spirit. This is important to understand. All effective evangelism is a catering to the Holy Spirit, and it is only when we lose sight of this that we leave the path of biblical orthodoxy. Our task is to give the Holy Spirit something to work with, and he can only work with the truth. In the case of Nicodemus the method succeeded for there is good reason to believe that Nicodemus was eventually saved (See John 7:50; 19:39).

The divine initiative, far from being a discouragement from evangelism, is actually an encouragement. We have already seen that becoming the sheep of Christ took place in eternity. This means that among the non-Christians of the world there are Christ's sheep; lost but his nonetheless. So how will they be brought into the fold? Surely, by people like us! They are simply waiting for an outreach minded Christian to explain the gospel to them and the Holy Spirit will do the rest. So they are already out there, eternally prepared and waiting. It doesn't get more encouraging than that.

We will close with a quote from 1 Corinthians 1:22-25.

> 22 For the Jews require a sign, and the Greeks seek after wisdom: 23 But we preach Christ crucified, unto the Jews a stumblingblock, and unto the Greeks foolishness; 24 But unto them which are called, both Jews and Greeks, Christ the power of God, and the wisdom of God. 25 Because the foolishness of God is wiser than men; and the weakness of God is stronger than men.

Appendix

OVERCOMING THE SINFUL NATURE

You don’t have to be a Christian for long to hear about the sinful nature. So what exactly is it? We know that it is a “nature”, i.e., a property of living beings that determines their behaviour. Take, for example, the cat. If you want an animal to take for a walk you would not get a cat. Why not? Because most cats (there is always the exception) don’t want to walk with their owners. The cat will happily walk on its own but not with you, and especially not on a leash. The RSPCA advises owners against walking cats on a leash. And if you are not convinced just take a walk on any late afternoon and you will see plenty of people walking their dogs but you won’t see anyone walking their cat. And it is not as though the cat can’t walk; it can. But the cat is, unlike a dog, not a pack animal but hunts alone using stealth to catch its prey.

So when we do things by nature we do what comes naturally. Any specific behaviour must be a natural function of who and what we are and there are only so many possibilities. For the unbeliever, the sinful nature is also limited by what it can do. It can do many noble things such as acts of heroism, generosity, compassion, love, kindness, patience …etc but despite all of these things we know from scripture that there is one thing it cannot do: it cannot love God. It is, in fact, quite opposed to

God and wants nothing to do with him (See Romans 3:10-18; John 3:19-20).

So how does the unbeliever ever manage to come to Christ? How does he repent and believe? Clearly, he needs a change of nature. Let me illustrate: a cat owner complains to a friend that he cannot get his cat to walk with him. “I’ve tried everything”, he says. “I’ve even planted cat food at various places along the way but to no avail”. His friend, a dog owner, says to him, “If you want an animal to walk with you try getting a dog.” We could put this another way: if you want your cat to walk with you try rebirthing it as a dog. Now that sounds ridiculous but it’s really not that far from the truth, and it was spot on the truth when Jesus told Nicodemus in John 1:3 ff that if he wanted to enter the Kingdom of God he would have to be born again, of water and the Spirit.

The problem with Nicodemus, and with all unbelievers, is not that they have a few impediments that need to be ironed out but that they have the wrong nature which they received from birth. So it is not what they do that is the problem; it is what they ARE. And it was at that level that Jesus recognised the problem in Nicodemus. He had to be born again, only this time from water (something clean) and the Spirit (the Holy Spirit). Man must receive a new nature so that he can respond to the gospel in faith and repentance. And this is what we call “regeneration”.

Recommended Reading

The following publications are recommended reading for those who want a more thorough defence of the divine initiative in the work of salvation:

Arthur W Pink, 2004 *The Sovereignty of God* . Grand Rapids: Baker Books

R C Sproul, 2002 *Grace Unknown, The Heart of Reformed Theology.* 5th printing. Grand Rapids: Baker Books

Frank B. Beck, 1986 *The Five Points of Calvinism*. Second Australian Edition. Strathpine Qld Australia. Covenanter Press.

Graeme Goldsworthy, 1991 *According to Plan*, Lancer Press, Anzea Publishers, Homebush West, NSW, Australia

John F MacArthur, *The Gospel According to Jesus* 1988, Zondervan Publishing House, Grand Rapids, Michigan.

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